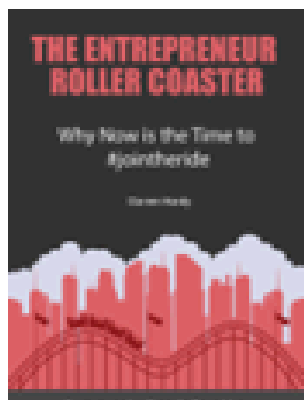




THE ENTREPRENEUR ROLLER COASTER

Why Now is the Time to #JointheRide

DARREN HARDY

The Big “So What”



Most people have no idea how to start a business nor what to expect. **This is a guidebook that explains what it takes to start a business and how to prepare yourself for the ups and down of the entrepreneurial roller coaster ride.** It offers useful insights for anyone deciding whether to start a business, or who wants to maximize his/her chances of success in business.

Introduction



Today, there are more opportunities than ever to start your own business. Technology has opened up new possibilities for individuals and small businesses which were previously available only to big corporations. In the last decade, global wealth has increased by 69% and there's been a spike in the number of new millionaires. Hardy urges you to grasp the opportunity and join the ride.

Hardy started his first business when he was 18 and earned \$20,000 a month by the age of 19. Although he has built several successful businesses—from door-to-door sales to real estate, online media and educational software—he has also made his share of mistakes.

In the book, he shares many stories and anecdotes from his own experience, as well as insights gained from interviewing top leaders and business magnates when he was the publisher of the SUCCESS magazine. The book is organized into 8 key chapters, with recommended action steps at the end of each chapter to be completed with **[free downloadable worksheets](#)**. In this summary, we've integrated the ideas from the book with key action steps from the worksheets.

KEY QUOTES

“This book is about helping you embolden that fiercely independent and powerfully self-reliant spirit that already resides inside you.”

“This is what business is like...a frightening, exhilarating, and totally addictive thrill ride.”

Meeting the Minimum Requirements



You need to be of a minimum height to get on a roller coaster. Likewise, **there are 3 minimum requirements to succeed in business.**

Find your Love/Passion



The entrepreneurial journey will be tough. Without love or passion, it's hard to stay the course. Passion is something that's already inside you and just needs to be switched on.

Q Your first role is to identify your switch, by considering 4 areas:

- Loving what you do. In reality, we can never be passionate about *everything* we do. What we see of someone's work is usually just a fraction of what they really do. We may see celebrities in the movies and on the red carpet, but we don't see the hours spent on casting, negotiations, research, meetings, makeup, traveling etc. Only 5% of our work is likely to be what we love; the other 95% is work that we don't love. Moreover, many of our passions are merely hobbies and can't be applied to our work.
- Loving why you do it. If you can find the outcomes that you can fall in love with (the "why"), you'll find it easier to bear with the 95% of the work you dislike. Hardy is driven by his passion for empowering entrepreneurs and helping people to achieve their desired results and success.
- Loving how you do it. Even the most mundane job—be it housekeeping or administration—can be motivating when you aim to deliver it to the highest standards. Bring excellence and passion to your work and people can't help but notice you.
- Loving who you do it for. You may also love your work because of the people who benefit from it, e.g. your loved ones or members of a community you care about.

KEY QUOTES

"Passion is like electricity in a light switch. It's always there...ready to be turned on."

"Don't over-romanticize the idea of being wholly passionate about what you do...Nothing is awesome all the time."

"Work is gonna suck 95% of the time. But that other 5% is freaking awesome!"

*"The two most important days in your life are the day you are born and the day you find out why."
- Mark Twain*

Find your Fight



We are driven by the pursuit of pleasure or the avoidance of pain. An “enemy” like injustice or poverty can trigger feelings of fear or anger which are powerful motivators. The key is to find something that fires you up and gives you the emotional drive to succeed in business.

Find your Strength



To succeed, you need more than sheer motivation. You must also identify unique advantages that will help you succeed in business. Over the years, Hardy discovered that his unique strength lies in his communication skills, and the businesses that thrived were those that tapped on his strengths.



Strength Training. After studying and interviewing many successful people for the SUCCESS magazine, Hardy found that success has nothing to do with your DNA or background; it's a result of mastery that comes from persistent hard work.

- The “10,000 Hour Rule” popularized by Malcolm Gladwell says that mastery comes from about 10,000 hours of deliberate, focused practice. Top performers in any field—from music legend David Foster to famous basketballer Michael Jordan—all attain mastery after years of repeated practice and learning. However, passion gives them an added boost to keep pushing for improvements and new heights.
- Don't let anyone tell you what you're born or not born to do. Only you yourself can choose where/how to invest your efforts.

Action Plan



Identify your Passion. Consider what you love about your current job/business in terms of what, why, how and who. If you don't love anything about your current vocation, then consider what you'd do if you already had all the money you want, what makes you feel most alive and fulfilled (and why), and who you'd trade places with professionally (and why).



Find your Fight. Consider what enemy is keeping you from what you love or care about. What are you willing to fight for?



Find your Strength. Consider what areas you stand out in, and what you do relatively effortlessly compared to others. Identify ways to build those strengths.

KEY QUOTES

“The reality is love and hate are the same thing—just looking in different directions.”

“DNA has nothing to do with success. Turn your genes into overalls and get to work.”

*“Everyone has talent, but ability takes hard work.”
- Michael Jordan*

Get Ready (Buckle Up)



One of the most challenging things about entrepreneurship is the amount of rejection and ridicule that you'll face. Even those closest to you may discourage you, tell you that you're crazy and try to convince you to follow the conventional path. Realize that the rejection is not about you; it's about them because you remind them of what they themselves dare not do.



Use these 5 strategies to crush these negative voices:

- Don't be likeable. When you create change and rock the status quo, it upsets people. Stop worrying about what others think about you and don't let their opinions hold you back. Treat disapproval and dislike as a sign that you're on the right track, rather than a sign of rejection or failure.
- Get laughed at. When revolutionary ideas like SpaceX and Disneyland were first conceived, people laughed at them. Arnold Schwarzenegger (an Austrian) faced his share of ridicule when he said he was going to become a big movie star in America, and again when he said he was going to become a governor in California. When people mock you, treat it as a sign that you have a truly original idea.
- Define success in your own terms. Most of us spend our lives trying to live up to others' standards. Hardy himself spent much of his life trying to gain his dad's approval, before he learned to define success on his own terms. Consider what real success means to you, what would bring you true happiness, joy and fulfillment, and how you'd measure it. Write it down.
- Realize most opinions don't matter. Most of the time, others are more interested in how you make them look, than in you or your idea. Before you allow yourself to be dragged down by someone's negative opinion of you, consider if that opinion really matters—will the person cry at your funeral or even attend it? The answer is probably "no".

KEY QUOTES

"People don't resent you for being brave. They resent themselves for being afraid."

"When you step outside the status quo, you become a giant mirror for those who stay, reflecting back their cowardice."

"If no one is ridiculing or laughing at you, you either don't have a revolutionary, change-making idea yet, or maybe you've been afraid to finally share it with the world."

*"Don't let the noise of others' opinions drown out your own inner voice, heart, and intuition."
- Steve Jobs*

"We all get knocked down. How quickly we get up is what separates us."

- Shorten your recovery time. So long as you're pushing yourself outside your comfort zone and trying/learning new things, you'll inevitably fail. In fact, you'll probably face repeated setbacks. Know that it's expected, give yourself some time to recover, then move on. Remind yourself that being rejected and knocked down are signs that you're growing and improving.

The surest way to fail is to quit. Crush the naysayers and persevere to achieve success on your own terms.

Action Plan



Identify the people holding you back and apply the strategies above.



Identify and write down your own definition of success

Power Up



As an entrepreneur, you'll find that there's way too much to be done in too little time. **To get results, you must focus on the right things.**

Know your main priority: Sales



The best businesses aren't the ones with the best products, star players, nor outrageous margins. 90% of the time, it's all about having great sales and marketing. Apple's iPod didn't take off until 3 years after its launch, because it changed its approach and convinced people that everyone should have "1,000 songs in your pocket".



No matter how big or small your business is, your #1 job is to sell.

- Many people find sales scary and try to hide behind other tasks on their to-do list. However, there's simply no hiding from it. Without sales, you have no business.
- Besides selling to customers (directly or via your sales team), you must also sell your vision to internal and external stakeholders, convince the right people to join you and give their best etc. You must sell to everyone, every day.

KEY QUOTES

"It is precisely in those moments of strife, struggle, and failure...that the true achievers are born."

"The ultimate success of a product or service is 10 percent product quality and 90 percent sales."

"You're going to sell. All day. Every day. That's business."

✓ The good news is, all of us are natural salespeople. As babies and kids, we intuitively “sell” to adults to get what we want, be it crying or turning on our charms. Yet we convince ourselves as adults that we can’t sell. Learn to build your sales muscles with these 9 steps.

- Don't think of your prospects as targets, as if they're on your hit list. Instead, think of them as people you're going to help. This simple switch in framing changes your entire sales approach to focus on what *they* want and how you can help *them* get it.
- The most vital ingredient of effective sales and marketing isn't conviction, passion, or even persistence. It's empathy. Take the time to put yourself in their shoes and feel how they feel. When you truly understand your customers, you'll use language that reflects who they are, who they aspire to be, and what they seek to do.
- In sales, the only need that matters is the perceived need of the customer. It's a common mistake to try and fill a need you think needs to be filled. Stop talking, pushing, pitching and assuming; instead, ask questions, probe for details, listen more and seek to understand your customers' perceived needs.
- Don't use a one-size-fits-all approach for everyone. To find the hot button for each customer, you must first connect with the customer by asking the right questions, then connect their desire or hot button with the solution you have.
- Don't do cold calls. Instead, find a "relationship bridge", or someone credible who can introduce or refer you personally to your desired client.
- Don't sell to one person at a time. Sell in bulk through influencers who have a ready network or access to customers.
- Make an impression by being shocking and awe-inspiring. When Hardy was in real estate, he'd show up at the prospects' doorstep on the morning their listing expired, and asked that they list with him. For 2 weeks, he'd follow up daily with a series of cheesy-but-memorable actions, e.g. sending a package of combustible materials and explain why he was

KEY QUOTES

"Want to sell more? Stop selling. Help instead."

"Sales is filling a customer's perceived need, not your need to sell something."

Da-Bomb, or having an assistant deliver a "SOLD" sign which they'd need if they hired Hardy. Such an aggressive approach may turn off a minority of people, but it gets the attention of the remainder.

- Focus 90% of your efforts on 10% of your best clients; They love what you offer, buy more and buy more frequently, are a joy to serve and tell their friends about you. Identify your best clients using these 3 criteria: (a) *they're easy to reach*, (b) have the biggest, most evident *perceived need* and see the value of what you offer and (c) *are profitable* (with a higher lifetime value in terms of the size and frequency of purchases and referrals).
- Find your Dream 50, i.e. people or organizations who can bring you millions of revenue if they buy into your product or service. Just securing a few of such relationships can transform your entire business.

Action Plan



Assess & re-prioritize your strategic focus. Rate where your business stands for each of these strategic areas: product/service, leadership/management, margins, sales & marketing. Identify the % of your time currently allocated to each of the areas above. Identify how you'd *reallocate your time* to reflect that 90% of your business success will come from sales and marketing.



Find & capture your Dream 50 using the sales strategies above. *Identify and list your Dream 50 customers. Put yourself in their shoes to consider their worries, fears, desires, goals, hopes and needs. Customize your solution to their unique pains, hopes and desires and consider how you'd show that you can give them what they want. Identify the relationship bridges to get introduced. Then go all out to shock and awe them.*

KEY QUOTES

"The key to greater profits is rarely capturing more clients. (It's) capturing more valuable ones."

Fill your Empty Seats



At some point, your coaster (or business) is going to take a plunge. Would you want the people riding with you (your team) to be fearful and paralyzed, or excited and ready to take on the challenge? Unfortunately, entrepreneurs tend to get so excited by people who love their ideas/vision that they overlook their skills/experience, or they try to hire people to put out fires rather than to bring their vision to life.

"You can't hire enthusiasm. You need to hire evidence... Hire evidence, not hope."

Hire only A-Players



You must hire people who already have the right skills, character and experience (and can show evidence of that).

- For an average business, 65-80% of the operating costs go toward staff wages. You simply can't afford to hire the wrong people, since the real costs include not just their salaries, but also the mistakes and missed opportunities.
- As a busy entrepreneur, you also don't have the time to train people from scratch.



You should only hire A-players (not B-players or C-players) because they make your work easier, improve your business and free you up to do what you need to do as the owner. More specifically:

- A-Players attract other A-players. Having the right people on your team can be the best recruiting tool.
- A-Players are winners, and it's your people (not your products and systems) that will shape your company.
- A-Players pay for themselves. Don't worry about paying more—someone who earns \$250,000 a year but brings in \$5 million revenues for your company is effectively free.

Build a High-Performance Culture



You can't dictate or shape your company culture; you can only hire people with the attributes desired for your culture. **Be personally involved in the hiring process and do these 3 things to recruit effectively:**

- Know what you want. You're looking for A-Players who're (a) better than you and can deliver what you can't, (b) have the character traits needed to succeed and form your desired culture (e.g. discipline, friendliness), and (c) can fall in love with what they'll be doing in your company.

KEY QUOTES

*"The single most important thing you need to do is pick the right people and keep them. There is NOTHING more important than this."
- Jim Collins*

"Your business will only be as good as the people you recruit to join it."

"A great person in the wrong environment is still the wrong person."

- Know what they want. Generally, people look for 5 things in their work: the ability to work with other great people, being part of a meaningful *challenge* (or purpose), having the *opportunity* to move up or progress in their career, the ability to *grow* and become more of who they want to be, and being fairly *compensated* for their contributions. Realize that money is just 1 of the 5 components.
- Make it fun. Having fun at work doesn't always mean playing billiards or having free meals in the office. When the 5 factors above are met and people are excited about what they do and who they're working with, work can be fun and fulfilling.

Action Plan



Take stock of the top 5-10 key positions, competencies and skills you need to become the market leader. Assess if your current people in these roles are A-Players, i.e. better than you in their roles, have the desired traits for your culture and are in love with what they're doing for your business. Identify the positions that must be upgraded.



Define what you want, including the role, job description, how success will be measured, the results you're paying for, and the attributes, competencies, character or qualities required.



Define what you can offer in terms of: people, challenge, opportunity, growth, money and fun.

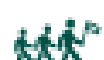
KEY QUOTES

*"What makes work fun is doing meaningful work."
- Cody Foster*

Take the Front Seat



In any organization, the quality of its leadership determines its performance. **As the leader, you must bear 100% responsibility for everything that happens in your organization—share the credit but own the blame.**

 To be effective in the 21st Century, leaders must:

- Lead by example. People watch what you do, not what you say. Lead from the front so people can follow you, never ask others to do something unless you've done it yourself, and act as if *everything* you do—from being late for a meeting to gossiping about a colleague—is being watched by others.
- Be willing to do what's right/necessary, even if it's unpopular.

"The number one bottleneck or constraint to the growth of any organization is the leader."

"Only ask for others to do what you have done yourself first."

- Bring out the best in your people. Encourage every member to contribute, facilitate engagement and co-creation, and help people to grow and thrive by removing fear, nurturing positive attitudes and beliefs, and investing in their personal growth.
- Let others lead. When you first start a business, you must do everything from sales to customer service and accounting. Aim to grow sales to a point where you can hire specialists to handle each function, so you can increasingly focus on leading.
- Know when to let people go. As your business grows, you may find that certain roles have outgrown the people currently doing them. Be prepared to redeploy or even let people go if they can no longer pull their weight or no longer fit.

 How you think and act as a leader affects others, and it's vital to set the right example. However, we tend to think that we're better than we really are. Develop yourself and your team members using the action plan below.

Action Plan



Improve your leadership. List down 20-30 important attributes you want in your team (e.g. discipline, drive, empathy). Then, select the 12 most vital attributes and plot them in the Leadership Development worksheet ([download it for free here](#)). Rate yourself (from 1-10) on how well you exemplify these attributes daily. Get at least 3 other people to rate you on the 12 attributes, then compare the scores and identify your areas for development.



Improve your team. Rate your top 5 leaders on the 12 attributes, get them to rate themselves and you, compare notes and discuss their development plan.

Do a re-evaluation every 90 days to track your progress. The goal is to eventually score 10 on all 12 attributes.

Pick Up Speed



As your business grows, you must become increasingly productive without being overwhelmed. Just like how doctors use vital signs (e.g. heart rate and blood pressure) to assess your health, **you need to focus on 4 vital factors to manage your business for success.**

KEY QUOTES

"You can't be a great leader if you spend your time doing tasks that aren't actually leadership."

"Every endeavour that you do has a few vital functions. All you have to do is figure out what they are and become excellent at them."
- Dr. Mehmet Oz

1. Your Vital Functions



Every job or junction has a few key things that matter the most. Track how you're spending your time in the day, then work on increasing the amount of time spent on your vital functions.

 **Know your value.** Calculate your hourly rate (personal annual income divided by annual work hours). Every task that you can hire for less than that hourly rate must be delegated or deleted. If you earn \$200,000 a year and work 2,000 hours, each hour of your time is worth \$100 and should not be spent on work worth less than that.

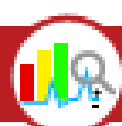
 Identify your top 3 vital functions/roles, then zoom in on the #1 vital function which only you can do, which you do best and contributes the most to your organization. Then, cut down everything that's not vital to free up time to focus on your #1 function. Track, measure, and master the skills needed to excel in this function.

2. Your Vital Priorities



These are the tasks you must perform well to accomplish your vital function. List down all your priorities (to-do items, key projects), narrow down to the top 3 priorities and say "no" to everything that doesn't contribute significantly to these 3 priorities.

3. Your Vital Metrics



Your metrics help you to know if you're on-track or off-track so you can do course-correction.

 List down 5-6 key metrics that make up the economic engine of your business and reflect your progress (e.g. # new customers) then identify the drivers behind these metrics (e.g. visits to store, new database opt-ins).

 Use the "Massive Transformation Formula" (MTF):

- Identify the Big 3 goals, which if achieved, will make this year the best year of your life. Throw the other goals away.

KEY QUOTES

"Just do the vital functions (amazingly well) and build a great team who are excellent at the rest."

"Activity is not productivity."

"Decide on a few critical things, do them more often, then get better at them."

- Identify the 1-2 key habits that'd be most crucial to achieving your Big 3 goals. Repeat them until you form the habits.
- Take 30 seconds daily to track and review how far you've achieved your Big 3 goals and key habits. Make adjustments and make up for the difference if needed.

4. Your Vital Improvements



To improve, you must go beyond learning and spend more time doing. Achieve significant and lasting improvements using these 3 steps:

- Identify the skills that are most vital to your Big 3 Goals;
- Commit part of your time and income to invest in yourself, e.g. attend a program or get a coach/advisor; and
- Rinse and Repeat. When you find something/someone that works for you, rinse and repeat to deepen the learning.

Action Plan



Calculate your hourly rate; delegate/delete everything that's worth less.



Define your 4 vital factors and get your team members to do the same.



Formulate your MTF and get your team members to do the same.

Hands in the Air



Entrepreneurs are not fearless risk-takers. **Everyone feels afraid at some point and it's all about facing your fears.**



Use these 6 brain hacks to conquer your fears:

- Realize that fear is not real. It's merely an illusion that arises from how our brains interpret something. The next time you're held back by your fear, ask yourself, "will this kill me?". The answer is probably "no".
- Don't fear your fear. Often, the anticipation of doing

KEY QUOTES

*"The brave man is not he who does not feel afraid, but he who conquers that fear."
-Nelson Mandela*

"The fear itself hurts more than the thing you are scared of."

something already evokes fear and such pre-fear can be even more damaging than the thing that you fear.

- You don't need to be brave all the time to succeed. You just need 20 seconds of courage, 3x a day, to do the things that'll make a difference, e.g. to say "no" or call your dream client.
- We tend to imagine the worst possible scenarios of how things can go wrong or how we will fail. Focus on the task and do it well; don't fret over imaginary outcomes.
- With enough practice, you can habituate yourself to fear, e.g. feel less fearful calling a prospect or stand on a public stage.
- Make failure fun, not scary. Massive failures can be the source of some of your most valuable lessons. Make a game of it: try to out-fail yourself and your competitors. It will involve lots of humiliation and pain initially, but these will eventually give way to results.

Action Plan



List down your fears and identify the **top 3 fears**. Ask yourself, will you die from it, how can you habituate it and make it fun.



Take 20s, 3x a day, to tackle your fears daily.

Smile for the Camera: Don't Miss the Point



In the pursuit of your goals, don't lose sight of what matters most.



Hardy shares several dos and don'ts to ensure you enjoy the ride:

- Don't follow others' path or their model of success. Define what you want, follow your own path and enjoy the journey.
- A bigger business may not always be better for you. Consider what you want at the end of the journey (e.g. health, freedom, love etc.) and do/track the things that'll get you there.
- Don't get distracted along the way or get discouraged by what others say. Stick to what matters most.

KEY QUOTES

"The activities you are most afraid of are the activities that can cause a breakthrough in your success. Step into them."

"The key to success is massive failure. Go fail!"

"Getting to the end of the ride is not the point. Being a successful rider isn't the point either. The point is enjoying the ride."

- Trust your gut. If you're unsure whether to pursue something, ask yourself if you'd look back when you're 80 and regret not doing it.



Use the action plan below to get clear on what matters most.

Action Plan



Identify your point. Write down WHO and WHAT you value the most. Ask yourself honestly if you're allocating most of your time and energy to these people/ priorities; if not, identify what will you do to change it.



Start with the end in mind. Write your obituary using the template provided online: consider how you want to be remembered, and start living that life today.



Identify your regrets. Ask yourself: If you died today, what would you regret and how can you prevent those regrets from becoming a reality?

KEY QUOTES

"Don't miss the point. Spend your days pursuing the things you want said in your eulogy."

Other Details in the Book to Look out For



This book is written like a workbook, and the tips are meant to be applied. You can supplement the key ideas in this summary with more examples/stories from the book and/or download the free worksheets at www.RollerCoasterBook.com/Resources.

About the Author



Darren Hardy is an American author, keynote speaker, advisor, and former publisher of SUCCESS magazine, with more than 20 years of experience in the personal growth and success industry. He has led three success television networks producing over 1,000 TV shows with famous thought leaders.

In December 2015, Hardy announced his decision to leave Success magazine as publisher to focus on new opportunities including speaking engagements, media appearances and private mentoring. Find out more about Hardy at www.DarrenHardy.com or access free mentoring tips at his website www.darrendaily.com.